
Hips and Hip Flexors

The muscles you don't think about that think
about you all day long

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Introduction

A BETWEEN-SESSIONS MODULE ON THE MUSCLES most responsible for chronic low back pain — and how to win them back.

I need to talk to you about your hip flexors. You probably don't think about them. They think about you all day long, and right now they're winning.

After 12+ years on the table, I can tell you that "tight hip flexors" is one of the most common findings I make on people who came in for something else entirely. They came in for low back pain. They came in for knee pain. They came in for general stiffness. And there it is — hip flexors that have been shortened for so long they've forgotten what their full length feels like.

The frustrating part is that hip flexors don't usually hurt directly. They don't ache. They don't throb. They just quietly pull on everything else and cause problems downstream that get blamed on the back or the knees or "getting older." Most people go years not realizing their hips are the source.

This module is to fix that.

CHAPTER 1

What the hip flexors actually are

WHEN PEOPLE SAY “HIP FLEXORS,” THEY’RE USUALLY talking about three muscles working as a group:

Psoas (pronounced “so-az”)

Deep muscle running from your lumbar spine, through your pelvis, attaching to the top of your thigh bone. It’s the only muscle in your body that directly connects your upper body to your lower body. Lift your knee toward your chest — that’s mostly the psoas firing.

The psoas is also a major stress muscle. It tightens up during fight-or-flight responses and stays tight if you’re chronically stressed. People who hold a lot of emotional tension often have psoas tightness without knowing why.

Iliacus

Runs from the inside of your pelvis (the iliac bone) down to the same spot the psoas attaches. Iliacus and psoas often get lumped together as “iliopsoas” because they do the same job and attach in the same place.

Rectus femoris

Front-thigh muscle, the long one running down the middle of your quadriceps. It crosses both the hip joint and the knee joint, so it flexes the hip AND extends the knee. When it's tight, it pulls on the kneecap from above — one of the hidden causes of knee pain that doesn't track to any specific injury.

These three muscles, working together, are what flex your hip — bringing your knee toward your chest, or your chest toward your knee.

CHAPTER 2

Why sitting destroys them

WHEN YOU SIT, YOUR HIPS ARE BENT AT ROUGHLY 90 degrees. The hip flexors are in their shortened position. They're not stretching, they're not lengthening, they're just compressed into a fold for hours.

Tissue follows the position you hold it in. After enough hours, the muscle fibers shorten. The connective tissue around them shortens. The fascia binds down. The nervous system updates its "normal" length for these muscles.

By the time you stand up, your hip flexors think their new shorter length is correct. They don't WANT to lengthen back out — that would feel wrong to your nervous system. So they don't. They stay short.

Then you sit again the next day, and the next, and the pattern reinforces.

For desk workers, drivers, anyone who sits more than 6 hours total per day, the hip flexors are almost guaranteed to be shortened. The question isn't whether they're tight — it's how tight, and what downstream problems they're causing.

CHAPTER 3

How tight hip flexors cause low back pain

THIS IS THE CASCADE I SEE ON THE TABLE ALL the time.

The psoas attaches to the lumbar spine (your low back vertebrae). When the psoas is short, it pulls on those vertebrae. The pull tips your pelvis forward and compresses your low back into excess arch.

Stand up after sitting for hours. Feel that pinch in your low back? That's your psoas pulling your lumbar spine forward while your low back muscles try to hold you upright. The two are working against each other and your back pays the price.

Over months and years of this, the low back muscles get chronically overworked just trying to stabilize against the psoas pull. They become tight, fatigued, and inflamed. People assume their low back is the problem. They stretch their low back. They get massages on their low back. The low back loosens temporarily and then locks right back up.

It locks back up because the source — the tight psoas — was never addressed. Treating low back pain

without addressing hip flexors is treating the smoke alarm and ignoring the fire.

CHAPTER 4

How tight hip flexors cause knee pain

THE RECTUS FEMORIS CROSSES BOTH HIP AND knee. When it's chronically shortened, it pulls upward on the kneecap with every step. Over time this creates an uneven tracking pattern — the kneecap doesn't glide smoothly in its groove, and the cartilage on the underside wears unevenly.

Some people get diagnosed with “patellofemoral syndrome” or “runner's knee.” Sometimes that diagnosis is accurate. But many cases respond dramatically to hip flexor work that's never been tried, because nobody connected the upstream cause to the downstream symptom.

CHAPTER 5

What actually helps

THREE MOVES. DONE DAILY, THEY RELIABLY lengthen tight hip flexors back toward their proper resting length.

1. The couch stretch

This is the best hip flexor stretch I know, and most people aren't doing it.

Find a couch or chair with a vertical back, or use a wall.

Kneel facing away from the couch. Place your right foot UP on the couch behind you, so your shin is vertical against the couch back. Your right knee is on the floor near the base of the couch.

Place your left foot flat on the floor in front of you, knee at 90 degrees.

Stand tall — chest up, shoulders back. Squeeze your right glute. Push your hip slightly forward.

You'll feel an intense stretch in the front of your right hip and thigh. This is the deep tissue release the typical kneeling lunge can't reach.

Hold 30 seconds. Switch sides.

If this is brutal the first time, that's your answer for why your low back hurts. Don't bail — hold it. The intensity is the work.

2. Hip circles

Stand on one leg (hold a wall or counter for balance if needed).

Circle the other hip in big, slow circles — knee tracking a wide arc through space. 10 circles clockwise, then 10 counterclockwise.

Switch legs.

This restores the rotational and circular range of motion that gets lost when your hips only do flex-and-extend all day.

3. The 90-90 hip position

Sit on the floor. Put your right leg in front of you, bent at 90 degrees — thigh pointing forward, shin perpendicular to your thigh, foot pointing to the left.

Put your left leg behind you, also bent at 90 degrees — thigh pointing to the left, shin perpendicular to your thigh, foot pointing back.

Both legs form 90-degree angles. Sit tall — don't lean. Breathe.

Hold 30 seconds. Switch sides (front leg becomes back leg).

This position tells you immediately how tight your hips are. Some people can't get into it at all — they tip backward. That's not failure, that's data. Sit on a pillow to make it more accessible if needed.

Do this every day and you'll be somewhere different in two weeks.

CHAPTER 6

Your daily 10-minute hip reset

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS MODULE, do this every day:

Minute 1-2 — Hip circles. 10 each direction, each leg.

Minute 3-5 — Couch stretch. 30 seconds each side, two rounds.

Minute 6-8 — 90-90 hip position. 30 seconds each side, two rounds.

Minute 9-10 — Glute bridges. Lie on your back, knees bent. Lift hips by squeezing glutes. Hold at top for 3 seconds. 15 reps.

That glute bridge at the end is important. Tight hip flexors often pair with weak glutes — the glutes haven't been firing properly because the hip flexor tension has kept them inhibited. Once you start releasing the hip flexors, you need to wake the glutes back up so they can do their job and prevent the hip flexors from re-tightening.

CHAPTER 7

When your hamstrings cramp on glute bridges

THIS HAPPENS TO A LOT OF PEOPLE THE FIRST few times. Their hamstrings take over the glute bridge entirely. Hamstrings cramp, glutes do nothing.

That tells you everything about why your low back hurts. Your glutes have been asleep for a long time. The hamstrings have been compensating. The low back has been over-stabilizing because nothing in the back of your hip is actually doing its job.

Keep doing the bridges. The glutes will start firing again within a couple of weeks. You'll feel the work move from your hamstrings into your butt where it belongs.

CHAPTER 8

What to expect

MOST PEOPLE WORKING THESE THREE HIP MOVES consistently for two weeks report:

- Low back pain reduces noticeably
- Easier to stand up after sitting
- Less “stiff” feeling first thing in the morning
- Improved walking gait (one of the first signs your hips are loosening)
- Sometimes knee pain quiets down without doing anything to the knee directly

The hips respond well to consistent attention. They’re not as fast-changing as the mid-back, but the improvements are durable once they happen.

CHAPTER 9

Closing

FIVE MINUTES A DAY ON YOUR HIPS. THAT'S THE ask. If your low back has been a problem for years, there's a real chance this is why.

The frustrating thing about hip flexor tension is that it gets blamed on everything else for years before anyone connects the dots. The good news is that once you connect them, the fix is straightforward — short daily work, done consistently.

Start with the couch stretch tonight. Both sides, 30 seconds each. Notice how intense it is. That intensity is the message your hips have been trying to send for a long time.

The companion workbook has a hip flexor self-test, a 7-day low-back-and-hip tracker, and three reflection prompts to help you connect what you find in your hips to what you've been feeling everywhere else.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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